

Kerala Assembly Elections 2026: Health sector achievements and frailties on focus

While the Left hails the achievements of the health sector over the past decade as unprecedented, high out of pocket expenditure, lack of adequate human resources despite improvements in infrastructure, and issues with Karunya Arogya Suraksha Padhati implementation contest the claim

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Public health has been at the centre of many ongoing election-time debates in Kerala, with the Left hailing the achievements of the health sector over the past decade as unprecedented, while the Opposition has been quick to point out that the frailties of the system are remaining hidden behind the propaganda over the Kerala model of health as the number one in the country.

Kerala has long been celebrated as a model of high health outcomes achieved at relatively low cost—strong maternal and child health indicators, low infant mortality, and high life expectancy. But the glaring paradox today is that despite high per capita government expenditure on health, the State today records the highest out of pocket expenditure (OOPE) in the country—59.1% of the total health expenditure—as per the last National Health Accounts.

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